

2025 BA-Eindwerkstuk Seminar

Class #3: Conducting a Literature Review

Workgroup 103

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Friday, 21 February 2025



**Universiteit
Leiden**

The question, problem & analysis

1. What is your question?
2. What is your problem?
3. What are your sources, and how will you analyze them?

Roadmap

1. **Types of Literature Reviews**
2. **Reflect**
3. **Best Practices**
4. **Example**
5. **Exercise**

Purpose of a Literature Review

- **Situates your research (question) in context:** Shows how your study extends, refines, or challenges existing work.
- **Identifies gaps in knowledge:** Reveals contradictions, unresolved questions, or overlooked areas in prior studies.
- **Motivates empirical strategies:** Shows what methods and empirical strategies are available and (sometimes) why these should be adjusted.
- **Establishes researcher credibility and relevance:** Demonstrates you've built upon a recognized foundation of scholarship.

Types of Literature Reviews

Argumentative Review

- **Purpose:** Critically examine a body of literature to support or refute an existing argument or assumption.
- **Approach:** Selectively include sources to develop a stance or “contrarian” viewpoint.
- **Watch out for:** Potential bias—argumentative reviews can overemphasize sources that favor one side.

Integrative Review

- **Purpose:** Summarize and synthesize past research to generate new perspectives.
- **Approach:** Include all relevant studies addressing the same research question or hypothesis.
- **Key value:** Creates or refines frameworks and theories.

Most common type in the social sciences.

Historical Review

- **Purpose:** Trace the chronological development of a theory, concept, or issue.
- **Approach:** Identify how a topic or scholarly conversation evolved through time.
- **Key value:** Provides historical context and identifies trends or turning points to inform future research.

Methodological Review

- **Purpose:** Focus on research methods rather than findings.
- **Approach:** Compare how studies collect and analyze data, exposing strengths, weaknesses, or patterns.
- **Key value:** Highlights new approaches, ethical considerations, and overlooked techniques in the field.

Systematic Review

- **Purpose:** Provide a comprehensive and unbiased summary of all available evidence on a focused research question.
- **Approach:** Follows predetermined, transparent criteria to search, evaluate, and synthesize existing research.
- **Typical in:** Clinical and health-related fields, but increasingly adopted in the social sciences.

Theoretical Review

- **Purpose:** Examine how theory or theories have evolved to explain a phenomenon.
- **Approach:** Explore existing conceptual frameworks; identify gaps or inconsistencies; propose new hypotheses.
- **Key value:** Helps establish the theoretical basis for your own study and points to directions for further research.

Reflect

Types of Literature Reviews (recap)

1. **Argumentative Review:** Support or refute an existing argument; watch for bias.
2. **Integrative Review:** Summarize and synthesize past research to propose new perspectives.
3. **Historical Review:** Trace the evolution of theories or topics over time.
4. **Methodological Review:** Focus on methods and approaches used, not just findings.
5. **Systematic Review:** Formal, exhaustive search with strict criteria; common in clinical/social sciences.
6. **Theoretical Review:** Examine how theories emerge and interrelate in your field.

You will mix and match depending on your question, sources, and methods

What about you?

- What is your “literature”?
- What kind of sources will you read?
- What kind of review(s) will you do?

Best Practices

Preparation

- **Clarify your research question:** Understand your main goal and how it fits existing studies.
- **Conduct targeted searches:** Use library databases, journal indexes, citation tracking, and curated bibliographies. Make good use of bibliographies of representative studies!
- **Collect and organize sources:** Gather essential studies (the “must-reads”) and categorize them thematically or chronologically. Work back from these.

Organization

- **Chronological Structure:** Good if developments clearly follow a timeline, but not always necessary.
- **Thematic (Conceptual) Structure:** Group studies by themes, subtopics, or shared concepts.
- **Methodological Structure:** Compare/contrast research designs, samples, and data analysis techniques.
- **Combination Approach:** Often, reviews combine two or more structures (e.g., chronological then thematic).

Reading

- **Summarize and evaluate:** Go beyond summarizing results; critique scope, evidence, and limitations.
- **Keep an annotated bibliography:** Include short, critical summaries and keywords for each source.
- **Track conceptual links:** Visual connections using digital or physical tools (tables, mind maps).
- **Manage references:** Use citation software (**Zotero**, Mendeley, EndNote) for organization.

Writing Tips

- **Integrate primary and secondary sources:** Bring in direct evidence where relevant, but maintain focus on *analyzing prior work*.
- **Look for patterns or consensus:** Determine convergences among studies, noting the main points of agreement.
- **Note conflicting perspectives:** Highlight where scholars disagree; show why it matters to your project.
- **Revisit and refine:** Reevaluate your sources and add new references as your own study evolves.

Example

From Division to Democracy: Integrating Post-Socialist Citizens in Germany and South Korea

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Abstract

This paper investigates how socialist legacies influence the political attitudes and integration of two post-socialist groups—former East Germans in reunified Germany and North Korean migrants in South Korea—whose experiences underscore broader challenges of transitioning to democratic societies. Drawing on choice-based conjoint experiments and supported by observational data analysis, the study examines individuals' preferences for hypothetical politicians with varying stances on political rule, economic organization, social welfare, gender, and cultural diversity. By comparing responses between primarily native-born citizens and post-socialist subpopulations, we assess the extent of attitudinal convergence and highlight areas where socialist-era socialization likely remains influential. In Germany, the findings show that attitudes toward diversity (i.e., national identity) diverge between Western Germans—who reject nativism and support multiculturalism—and Eastern Germans and post-GDR citizens, who remain more skeptical despite formal unification. In South Korea, North Korean migrants show less enthusiastic support for democracy than native South Koreans, suggesting that early political socialization under authoritarian socialism leaves lasting imprints on democratic outlooks. This study underscores the enduring quality of formative political experiences, illustrating that effective democratic integration requires more than institutional change. It also considers how deeply held beliefs formed under socialism persist and shape contemporary political preferences—offering valuable lessons for policymakers in divided or transitioning societies.

Keywords: Socialization, socialist legacies, social integration, Germany, South Korea

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From Division to Democracy I

- **Question:** How do socialist legacies shape the political attitudes and integration of individuals transitioning from socialist systems to democratic contexts?
- **Problem:** Despite formal unification (in Germany) or unification in process (South Korea), political and social attitudes formed under socialism may endure under democratic rule and create social discordance. Previous studies suggest this, but they use a limited range of questions presented in overly simplistic ways.

From Division to Democracy II

- **Type of review:** Integrative and (some) methodological
 - We synthesize multiple strands of scholarship (political socialization, post-communist legacies, re-socialization processes, and integration outcomes) rather than simply listing prior findings or arguing for a single viewpoint. We show how prior socialist experiences can influence democratic attitudes, and we highlight the methods used.

From Division to Democracy III

- **Situate Research Problem:** We position the study of *post-socialist citizens* within the broader literature on *political socialization*.
- **Highlight Inconsistencies/Gaps:** We point out that while scholars agree socialist-era socialization has lasting effects, there is mixed evidence on *which* attitudes change or remain (e.g., attitudes toward democracy, welfare, diversity).
- **Establish rationale for a new empirical approach:** We note that prior research relies on general survey measures or country-level comparisons. We propose a more realistic “choice-based conjoint” experiment to capture subtle, trade-off-oriented preferences not easily inferred from conventional surveys.

Exercise

Exercise

Generate an annotated bibliography* and a draft outline of the literature review.
Due to Brightspace by 23:59 on February 27 (Thursday).

You should use this in your revised proposal.

***Min. of 5 sources with the following annotations:**

1. *Full Citation*: Provide the complete reference (Chicago Style) so readers can locate the source easily.
2. *Summary of Main Ideas*: Briefly outline the source's central argument(s), key findings, or themes (~2 sentences).
3. *Relevance or Evaluation*: Note the source's strengths, weaknesses, or importance for your research topic, indicating how it is connected to the research question (~2 sentences).

Resources

USC Library's overview here of literature review types:

<https://libguides.usc.edu/writingguide/literaturereview>

Grant, Maria J., and Andrew Booth. "A Typology of Reviews: An Analysis of 14 Review Types and Associated Methodologies." *Health Information & Libraries Journal* 26, no. 2 (2009): 91-108. Accessed March 11, 2024. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1471-1842.2009.00848.x>

Leiden University 'Subject guide'* on a systematic literature review:

<https://www.library.universiteitleiden.nl/subject-guides/systematic-reviews>

* Many different resources are found in the university's subject guides!